The Turning

Read this before the first session. It says what the world is, and how to make a character who lives here. The cards in the world book are the full rules. This primer is the first reading.

What this world is

Vampires, werewolves, and their kin live in the Turning. The people around them know what they are. Towns accept them, employ them, and need them. Each one is a neighbour with a job and a cost.

You are born a Kind. Most people also become a Condition. Both are true at the same time.

Towns have charters, guild halls, markets, letters of credit, mills, and universities. There is no printing press and no gunpowder. Past the mills and the letters of credit, the new work is what a Condition can do. A voice carries past a storm. A Gaze holds a wound still. A second body does the heavy labor. A Tithe is the upkeep that makes that work possible.

The present year is Cut-year 387. Years are numbered from the First Cut. This age is the Years of Hands. A town Tree is the ordinary way a child Turns.

Kind and Condition

Kind is the body you are born in. Human, Elf, Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, Yumboe, and the other Daggerheart ancestries are Kinds. A Kind is ordinary. Nobody stares at a fox-tail in a market, or at wings on a ridge. A Kind does not keep a country of its own. The place you live in raises you.

Condition is what you become. About three people in four acquire one over a lifetime. About one in four never do. Law, guilds, medicine, and ordinary jobs are built around what a Condition can do, and around helping the person meet its cost.

A Condition arrives in one of two ways.

At the Leaf-Fall, a coloured leaf falls on a child, and a Condition is Given. If the leaves hug the child and no colour falls, that child is one of the Kept. The Tree left them as they are. The town watched the hug. The Kept are wanted in their own right.

Some people are Struck later. There is no leaf and no ceremony. They died and came back, they swore a contract, they survived a drowning, they survived being turned to stone, or they were lost and dying in the deep wild and the wild took them in. A ten-year-old cannot die and walk back. A child cannot swear a contract. The Tree does not Give a contract. Some of the Kept are Struck later.

Counted across a whole life, about sixty people in a hundred are Given, about fifteen are Struck, and about twenty-five stay Kept. At the ceremony itself, about forty children in a hundred are hugged. A little over a third of those hugged children are Struck someday. Kept names the present. It does not promise that no threshold will come.

A child who never stood under a Tree is UnTurned. A missed week, a refusal, and a week under a Tree that could not Turn all end the same way. Neighbours sometimes say Kept. The law says UnTurned. A Kept person was hugged while the town watched.

Every Condition carries a Tithe. You meet that upkeep in order to live well with what you became. Meet it, and you are a valued citizen. Fall behind, and the cost shows in the body. A Long-Lived starts to forget. A Two-Bodied person shifts at a bad moment. A Far-Voiced person lets a feeling out as a Cry. One of the Stilled locks a limb. An Answered person lets an element go in a crowded room. You still choose what you do. A Tithe does not take a person over. No Condition can compel another person.

You carry one Condition. The card does not grow when you level. The card at level 1 is the card at level 10. It sits in your loadout the way a heritage card does, and it does not count against your domain cards.

The Leaf-Fall

A Turning Tree stands in the square, on the green, or in a temple-yard. For most of the year it looks like a great oak or beech, and it is its own kind of tree. Children climb the low boughs. A court can meet in the shade. Cutting a mark into the bark is taboo.

There is one origin Tree, the Awakening Tree. The old spelling is Thaeloren, said THAEL-or-en. Everyday speech calls it the Thallow. It stands on Maiethorn, in the old country people call the Sacred Core. Every town Tree is a living graft of that wood. Wardens cut a piece, carry it in living earth, and plant it. The piece on the road is a scion. A newly planted Tree cannot hold a Leaf-Fall. People reckon that wait as about a generation. Until then the children go to a neighbour's Tree.

The Leaf-Fall is held in Turning-Week. That week holds the High Solstice, in midsummer. Every child who has turned ten since the last solstice stands under the canopy. The town's tree-warden says what the leaves did. The town watches. The week is a rite, and it is also the town's great fair.

The colour of the leaf names the Condition.

Leaf	Condition
Deep red	Long-Lived
Storm-grey	Two-Bodied
Lamp-amber	The Answered. The shade names the element: Ember (fire), Tide (water), Root (earth and stone), or Gale (air)
Sea-blue	Far-Voiced
Pale stone	The Stilled
Copper-green	The Taken-In. This green is metallic. It is not the Tree's summer green
White-fire	Phoenix. Almost no living town has seen this leaf. A town-warden sends word of it to the First Seat, the wardens at the Awakening Tree, rather than announcing Phoenix in the square

A hug is the Tree's own summer green. It has no naming colour.

Returned, Bound, and the Unbound have no leaf-colour. The Tree Gives, or it Keeps. A Strike happens later, away from the Tree.

A child has one week for a Gift, in the tenth year. A completed standing happens once. That is a colour, or a hug, under wood the warden called sound. The warden's announcement is the Speaking. If it misnames the colour or the hug, the Speaking can be corrected. The standing itself happens once.

A sick Tree is skipped. The children use a neighbour's Tree in that same week. If they stand under wood the warden knows cannot Turn, the week is spent, and those children are UnTurned. Next summer they may visit the square. The visit is not a second Gift.

A city keeps one Tree and the same one week. A hearth stands for the child: a quay, a courtyard, or a guild-stair, people who already know them, in a morning, an afternoon, or an evening. The warden says the colour or the hug out loud. Threnmaieth, said THREN-mai-eth, writes the stand down. Other towns leave it spoken. A village still watches as one circle.

Some people hold that the Leaf-Mother blessed the world with these gifts, and that the Trees are her hands. Neighbours call that faith the Motherfaith. Its own name is Maieth. Skeptics say the Trees do what a plant does. Both kinds of people stand in the same week. You belong by what you do. You bring the children, you tend the Tithe, and you keep the festival. People argue whether a hug is a gift of being left whole or a child passed over. They argue whether a Strike is still her doing or came some other way. Nobody in the square has closed those questions.

The ten Conditions

Nine of these can be chosen at character creation, when the path allows. The Unbound comes only when a Bound term ends. Each share is a share of all people. The Unbound's share sits inside Bound's share. It is not added on top.

Far-Voiced, the Stilled, and the Taken-In can be Given or Struck. Most of them are Given. For each of those three, the Struck are about one person in a hundred. Long-Lived, Two-Bodied, the Answered, and Phoenix are Given only. Returned and Bound are Struck only.

The sentence that begins with **Tithe** is the upkeep. Most Tithes are checked once at a long rest. Two short rests in one day leave the tokens as they are. Far-Voiced, Two-Bodied, Bound, and Phoenix use a different time, and the sentence says so. The card lists any step between a first miss and the end named here.

Long-Lived. Old tales called them vampires. Given only, by the deep-red leaf. About 2.5 percent of people. Aging stops. They forget nothing they have witnessed, and one drop of blood shows them a true memory from the person it came from. They keep records, and they wait to be asked through a door. They can have children. Most of those children do not inherit the Condition. Violence, an accident, or a failed Tithe can still kill them.

Tithe. Three Memory tokens, checked at a long rest. Refill them if, since the last rest, you spent Hope to recall a witnessed detail in full, read a memory from a drop of blood, or spent a downtime move in study or in witness. Otherwise remove a token. At none you are starving. A long rest that is still at none marks a Stress, and then a Hit Point. The last Hit Point taken this way is death, and there is no death move. You go still.

Two-Bodied. Old tales called them werewolves. Given only. About 18 percent. You carry a second animal self, from about a housecat's size up to a wolf, a bear, a boar, or a horse. That animal has its own name and its own mood. You choose when to change, and you choose every action. The Condition often runs in a family, as the same animal.

Tithe. Spend part of each day as the animal. If a full day passes without that, the next roll with Fear shifts you, and you mark a Stress. You still choose what the animal body does.

Returned. Old tales called them zombies. Struck only, and only by a death. About 7 percent. You died with a thing unfinished, and that Purpose keeps you walking. Plague wards, collapses, and the care of the dead are Returned work. Gore and deathly places do not shake you. Avoid Death is closed, because you have already died once. When you would die, you may Blaze of Glory, Risk It All, or Refuse to Fall. Refuse to Fall crosses out a Hope slot. You cannot Refuse to Fall if that would cross out the last Hope slot. When the Purpose is finished, you choose with the GM: lie down, live on with no Condition, or name a new Purpose and keep walking.

Tithe. If a long rest passes with nothing done toward the Purpose, mark a Stress you cannot clear until you act toward it, and your touch runs cold.

Bound. Old tales called them demons. Here the demon is the contract, not the birth. Struck only. About 5 percent of people are on this path, counting those who have already finished a term. About 3.5 percent are Bound now. You swore in extremity. A counterparty granted one small power your class does not already give you. You named Terms, which are the standing duties, and a Pledge, which is the piece of you paid when a limited term ends. An Infernis is born with demon blood. That blood is Kind. The oath is the Condition. The blood and the oath stay separate. A Bound person who signs contract after contract, until the other party effectively holds them, is called the Given-Over. A player character does not take that fate.

Tithe. Keep the Terms and the power works as written. Break a Term, or miss a payment, and the GM gains a Fear. Until you make restitution, the power costs a Hit Point instead of a Stress. While you are behind, a roll with Fear can bring a whisper, a thought or a lie. You may act against it. Shutting it out costs a Stress. The whisper does not choose your action.

The Unbound. People also say the Hollow. This is what a finished term leaves, not a Condition you pick off a list. About 1.5 percent, inside the 5 percent above. The counterparty takes the Pledge, and you go on without that piece. The missing piece is also a narrow immunity, agreed with the GM, against Stress or Fear that would have come through what was taken. You start here only if the table agrees that a Bound term has already ended.

Tithe. Three Quiet tokens. Spend one to act through the absence, or to gain advantage where the absence makes the hard thing easier. At a long rest, refill them only if a person who knows your name shares the meal or the watch. At none, an offer of power looks unusually reasonable, and refusing it costs a Stress. You can still refuse.

Far-Voiced. Old tales called them sirens. Given or Struck. About 12 percent. Your voice travels as far as you mean it to, through distance, storm, fighting, or water, and it carries the feeling you intend. A Given Far-Voiced drew the blue leaf and was trained. A Struck Far-Voiced survived a drowning and was not trained. Same Condition. Different life.

Tithe. Three Breath tokens. A long rest does not refill them. When you mark Stress from a feeling, or the GM names grief, terror, rage, or joy in the scene, you sing, cry, laugh, or weep before the scene ends. If you do not, remove a token. At none, the next strong feeling breaks out as a Cry. Everyone who hears it marks a Stress. You mark a Stress. The tokens refill to two. The people who hear it still choose what they do.

The Stilled. Old tales called them gorgons. Given or Struck. About 7 percent. Your Gaze can pause a bleeding wound, a spreading poison, or a struggle you can see. The pause does not harm the person you hold. A Given Stilled trained from the pale leaf. A Struck Stilled survived being turned to stone. Guilds licence the Gaze, because the same look can hold a fighter still.

Tithe. Grey tokens start at none. Add one each time you use the Gaze. Add one at a long rest that included no spar, drill, fight, or other hard physical work. A scene of that hard work clears one token at the end, if you marked Stress from the effort or you dealt or took damage. At three tokens, one of your own limbs locks stone-still, or a small thing nearby turns to stone. The tokens then clear to one.

The Answered. Old tales called them djinn. Given only. About 10 percent. One element answered at the Tree and keeps answering: Ember, Tide, Root, or Gale. You shape it with your hands. Once each long rest you may ask it one question it can feel through fire, water, stone, or air. It answers you. It does not answer another person’s order. The element does not tell the town what sort of person you are. That is why people call them a wildcard.

Tithe. Three tokens, checked at a long rest. Refill them if you spent Hope on the element’s Reach since the last rest. The question does not refill them. Otherwise remove a token. At none, the element lets go in your body, or in the air, water, and ground immediately around you. Other people take no direct harm from that. The tokens refill to two.

The Taken-In. Old tales called them leshy. Given or Struck. About 13 percent. Bark, moss, antler, or root shows on the body, and living plants lean toward you. Farms, herds, and wild roads depend on this work. A city crowd often keeps a little distance. A Given Taken-In grew up with the green. A Struck Taken-In was lost and dying, and the wild kept them alive.

Tithe. Three Green tokens, checked at a long rest. Refill them if you can touch a living plant where you rest. A tree, a field, or a window-box counts. Open sky with no plant does not. Otherwise remove a token. At none, mark a Stress, and you are Vulnerable until you touch living land. The room around you grows over. The tokens refill to two. That growth does not harm the people in the room.

Phoenix. People call them what the stories call them. Given only. The Tree is the only way one begins. Fewer than one person in a thousand, and only one Phoenix is alive in the whole world at a time. Fire and heat do no harm. You have wings of fire, and you can fly. While the wings are hidden you can pass for a moment. The moment you fly, anyone

watching knows what you are. Each rise costs a piece of the old life. Every other player agrees before anyone plays a Phoenix. The GM may instead have the party meet the Phoenix as someone already in the world. If the Phoenix is not the public legend, the other players agree first, in the same way, and that player and the GM work out the rest.

Tithe. Each time you Rise From Ash, cross out a Hope slot. You return with your Hit Points cleared and your Stress still marked, and you are Vulnerable until your next rest. You cannot rise if that rise would cross out your last Hope slot. That death is final. After it, a leaf falls somewhere for the next Phoenix. There is never a second living Phoenix while this one can still rise. A person who looks like a second Phoenix is not one.

Four ancestries

The stock Daggerheart ancestries live in the same towns as everyone else. If both of your ancestry features come from stock ancestries, take a Hearth-Mark. Name the place that raised you. Write a place, not a Kind. Once each session, on a roll that leans on how that place taught you to live, add +2. That +2 costs no Hope. You may still spend Hope to add an Experience on the same roll. A character who takes any feature from Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, or Yumboe takes no Hearth-Mark.

Two ancestries can mix, by the SRD rule. One parent gives the first feature on their list. The other gives the second feature on theirs. A custom Kind's third feature stays on the full Kind only. If either feature you took is from a custom Kind, you take no Hearth-Mark. Yumboe is taken whole. A Yumboe character needs the GM's leave.

Kitsune are fox-born. They have fox ears, one brush of tail, and foxfire at the fingertips. A child takes after one parent: Wilds in the woods, Snows in the high cold, or Sands in the dry country. A Kitsune can slip aside from a blow, and can wear a glamour. The glamour changes what another person sees or hears. It does not change the Kitsune's body. The other person still decides what to do. Stories tell of nine tails. That number is an honorific. The body has one tail.

Selkie carry a sealskin. It is a second self, put on or set down in a moment. In the water they are not harmed by the cold, they hold a long breath, and they know which way the surface is. A grip does not keep them. They always know the direction back to the place where they left the skin. Loaning the skin, or having it taken, is a question of trust in the story. The sheet has no penalty for it. Selkies are most numerous on coasts. Kumbaan has none by birth.

Tengu have wings, and their homes are ridges and cliff-shelves. They can fly. They feel a storm, a rockfall, or bad ground in time to act, or in time to shout a warning. Only a Tengu is protected from being caught off guard, and the protection is the storm, the rockfall, and the bad ground. A person waiting in hiding can still catch a Tengu. Tengu in a lowland port are usually a courier's family, not a whole town of ridge-folk.

Yumboe call themselves the good people. They are the people of Kumbaan, about waist-high to a mainlander, and they are awake at night. On the isle they are ordinary neighbours. Off the isle, most towns have only the story. With the GM's leave, the character has the full set: at home under the hill, clear-sighted in the dark, and able to call hands and feet that have no body between them. Those hands fetch, pour, and serve. Damage is outside that work, and so is holding a creature that means to get free. The isle has no Turning Tree, so a Yumboe there is not Given a Condition. A Struck Condition can still happen, and on the isle it is rare.

The faiths

Five faiths are lived side by side. You belong to one by the rite you keep, not by a test of belief. Many houses keep more than one rite. The Leaf-Mother is a belief. The other four are beliefs as well.

The Motherfaith, Maieth, is the common faith where Trees stand. It says a Condition is a gift that was chosen, and a hug is a gift of being left whole. Bringing the children, tending the Tithe, and keeping the festival are what make you part of it.

The Watching, Haelthael, is Maiethorn's old Tree-faith. They stand at the same Leaf-Fall. They will not call the Tree a mother. They say the colour is a seeing.

The Fair Hand, Leddoren, belongs to Strandoren's ports and counting-houses. It says a Condition is a bargain, the Tithe is the term you pay, and a paid term leaves you even.

The Old Ways, Vaeloren, are the faith of Heskoren from before the grafts arrived. They say rivers, oath-stones, and groves were already making people, and a planted Tree is a guest.

The Open Table, Ndeyaan, is the faith of Kumbaan. There is no Tree on the isle. The rite is supper. The house sets an extra place. A stranger who is fed on a second night is kin. A mainland watch does not take that kinship as papers.

The lands

Reach is how far the grafts have spread. Close to the Awakening Tree, towns have many old Trees. Farther away, the Trees are fewer and younger, and more children miss a standing or are Struck alone. Beyond the last capes, one isle has no Tree at all.

Maiethorn, the Motherland, is the eastern continent. Say it mah-YETH-orn. The Awakening Tree stands here, and the reach is full. More children are Given here than in the world as a whole. A hug is less common here than elsewhere. It is not rare. Every school on Maiethorn has Kept children. The powers here are Threnmaieth, Maiethvael, Orenbren, Saelthael, the Hinge Shore, and Lirorn. The Watching and the Motherfaith argue at this centre.

Strandoren, the Shore-lands, lies west across the Old Crossing, the inner sea. Say it stran-DOR-en. People often say Strandor. The reach is high. The long coasts live by trade. The powers here are Lestrand, Brenledd, Leddvael, Trenledd, and Netstrand. The Fair Hand is at home in these ports.

Heskoren, the Sundered Reach, lies farther west and south. Say it hesk-OR-en. People often say Heskorn. The reach is thin, and the planting is not finished. The powers here are Vaethorn, Ornled, Vaelhesk, and Saelvaeth. Say Vaethorn as Wetorn. The Old Ways keep the old doors here. Vaelhesk has no capital. The land itself is the seat.

Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle, lies past Heskoren's last capes. Say it koom-BAHN. Sailors also say the Sunder. A storm-wall of weather, current, and reef wrecks most crossings. No graft has ever crossed, and the isle has no Tree. The Yumboes live here. The Open Table is theirs.

Those lists are the fifteen powers, one set to each of the three large continents. The isle is a home. It is not a sixteenth power. The three famous corners are Threnmaieth on Maiethorn, Lestrand on Strandoren, and Vaethorn on Heskoren. Lestrand is said LES-trand.

On the mainland, a day's walk runs from one mile-shrine to the next. A watch asks your name, the last hearth you belonged to, and who will stand for you. Two of those three answers are enough. Kumbaan does not use that custom.

Daily life

An ordinary household is mixed. A Selkie and a Returned person can be married. A Kept grandparent can share the house. The children have not Turned yet. They will not Turn until the tenth year. A house like that has no special name.

Until the Leaf-Fall, a parent lives with one open question. The question is what the child will become, or whether the leaves will hug them.

A Long-Lived person stops aging. A spouse does not, and neither does a child. People say the cost of that Condition is counted in funerals. They mean the spouses and the children a Long-Lived person buries. Afterward, that person may live on alone, or marry again and outlive the next household too.

A town is laid out around its Tree. It also builds for Tithes the way it builds a well. Far-Voiced people use a hall where a feeling can be aired. Taken-In people use a public planting, or pots of living plants. Long-Lived people use a library. Two-Bodied people use open ground at the town's edge, where the animal body can work. Infirmaries of the Stilled, and workshops of the Answered, stand a little aside, because a bystander can be hurt there. The Returned tend the dead and walk into plague wards, so the living are not the ones sent in.

A household can be too poor to meet a Tithe. They can see what their kin needs. They cannot always buy it or house it.

Feed a guest before anyone asks who the guest is. A funeral is a walk and then a meal. It is not a Leaf-Fall. Neighbours carry the body along the street the person used, past the canopy. The body is not stood under the branches for a colour.

Being a Condition is not a crime. Three licences exist, for the Stilled, the Far-Voiced, and the Answered. A licence names a hazardous use: the Gaze, the Cry, or an element let loose. It does not name the Condition itself. A Bound contract is heard at a table. That hearing is not a fourth licence.

Making a character

Do this once, in this order.

1. **Kind.** Take a stock ancestry, or Kitsune, Selkie, or Tengu, or a full Yumboe if the GM agrees. Or mix two ancestries as the SRD allows: the first feature from one parent, the second feature from the other. If both features are stock, add a Hearth-Mark.
2. **Community.** Take a Community as the SRD defines it. The Hearth-Mark does not fill this line.
3. **Class, Experiences, and equipment.** Take these as the SRD defines them. Write two Experiences.
4. **Turning.** Write one of these four on the sheet.

- **Given.** A colour fell when you were ten. Take Long-Lived, Two-Bodied, the Answered, or Phoenix, or take Far-Voiced, the Stilled, or the Taken-In.
- **Kept.** The leaves hugged you, and the town saw it. You have no Condition card and no Tithe. You owe no guild for a Condition, and you hold no Condition licence. At a long rest you take downtime while other people may be marking a Tithe. That rest, with nothing to mark, is the tradeoff. Being Kept grants no extra Experience and no power of its own.
- **Struck.** The threshold is already in the backstory. Name the person who stood for you afterward. Take Returned or Bound, or take Far-Voiced, the Stilled, or the Taken-In.
- **UnTurned.** You never stood under a Tree. You have no card. The sheet says UnTurned. Kept would mean the town watched a hug.

5. **The table agrees.** Every other player agrees before a Phoenix is played. If that Phoenix is not the public legend, the other players agree first, and the player and the GM work out the rest. The Unbound is not a starting card unless the table agrees the term already ended.

Kind and Condition remain two lines on the sheet. A Selkie can be Given Two-Bodied. A Human can be Struck Returned. An Infernis who swears is Bound, and the born blood stays a Kind.

During play, a Kept or UnTurned character can be Struck when the story crosses one of the thresholds above, and only if that player agrees to take the card. A failed roll is not a reason to hand someone a Condition. Long-Lived, Two-Bodied, the Answered, and Phoenix cannot be Struck. They are Given only. There is no second Leaf-Fall.

Play a neighbour, a colleague, or a member of a family. The part of this world that is frightening is rare. It sits in a Tithe that is going unpaid, or in a tenth year that was missed. The Leaf-Fall is a warm week.